MCP

Title:
Remember One Word

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Remember One Word
Tammie Peters

You are my lawyer, no? You will help me stay in America.

Yes, it has been a very long journey. But I had no other choice.

You want to know my story? My cousin told me to say “asylum.” It is supposed to be a magic word. Asylum. You know?

Okay. I am Inez. I grew up in Honduras, in San Pedro Sula. Do you know it? It is a very bad place. I could not stay any longer or I would die. The *maras* would get me.

We did not always worry about the *maras. Mi familia* had a small home — it was very nice, it even had a real floor, not dirt like our neighbors. My *mama* was beautiful and she found lovely pieces of cloth to hang on the plain walls to make the rooms pretty.She would sing to us with the voice of an angel. My *papa* was strong and he worked for the factory. He was tall and had a very bushy mustache that would tickle me when he carried me. And he had a beautiful booming voice that sounded like thunder in a rainstorm. And there were two of us children: me and my older brother, Tomas. We lived happily together in our little home. I had a sweet little doll, who was all mine.

But then the troubles began when I turned 10.

My *papa* became angry at the government. He would talk about how bad President Sosa was for the country. He would complain about how weak the government had become. He would come home from work and tell us about bribes he saw officials take. He saw the military *chafarote* beat a man on the streets until he passed out. Papa was furious and he wanted to change things. He wanted to organize the workers, maybe call a strike. *Mama* begged him not to do anything. The next day, Antonio, a neighbor who worked with *papa*, ran into our home, gasping, “He’s dead. Your husband was yelling about corruption and the *chafarote* shot him.”

Oh, *papa*!

That left *mama* alone with the two of us. *Mama* had to find work. There weren’t many choices; she went to the *maquila* to make panties. *Mama* didn’t sing much after that. Her job didn’t pay very much, but when she worked we ate pretty well. When there was no work for her, Tomas and I went “hunting.” Sometimes, we got food from the church — *Americanos* would sent us *arroz,* powdered milk, *frijoles.* That’s when I learned about how kind the *Americanos* are. Sometimes we could get stale bread from the bakery. There were times when there was no food — so we’d make up games to keep our minds off of our hunger.

One of my favorite games was to pretend to be explorers and search for treasure amid the garbage. Sometimes we would find small shiny objects that had once been parts of a lamp or a bit of broken jewelry, and Tomas would make things for me and Mama. He wanted to dress her up like a princess, he said. He wanted her to feel special. So he would find little bits of wire and abandoned beads or broken bits of glass and then create wonderful little pieces of art: necklaces, earrings, pins . . . he was very talented. We knew that one day he would become a famous jewelry make or an artist with a gallery. Mama always showed the neighborhood women Tomas's newest works. That's how he cut his hand once. He was rummaging through some trash and the lid of a tin can cut his hand: a semi-circle just where the thumb connects. It wasn't deep -- we were able to stop the bleeding quickly. But the scar: a perfect half-circle. Tomas called it his smile -- his hand always smiled at him and at the world. He was like that.

Tomas was 13 at the time. He wanted to work--to provide money for mama--, but there were no real jobs for such a young boy, unless he joined the *maras,* the gangs.

There were two *maras* in our area: *Mara Salvatrucha* and *Calle dieciocho.* You may have heard of them as MS13 and 18th Street. They were very bad. They moved cocaine through our city, and they bought and sold girls. They would threaten shop owners with beatings if the shop owners didn't pay them part of the money they made. Sometimes, they would kill shop owners. They would pull girls out of their homes and rape them in the streets. Sometimes they would do that to the mothers. . . Or the grandmothers. They were constantly at war. We never went out after dark. Every night, after sundown, we all heard the gunfire. Sometimes, in the morning we would find new bullet marks in the side of our little house.

We all knew the stories of what happened to boys who wouldn't join them. They might be tortured with dripping battery acid, or they might have several bones broken. Or. . . something.

Tomas didn't want to join a gang. He hated what they did. He hated the violence. He wanted to work to earn money. He wanted to create beautiful things.

Both gangs pressured him. One day, he even spit on the boy who delivered the message. That was a huge mistake. That night, Tomas did not come home after the sun set. We waited all night, and worried about him. Mama held the bits of jewelry he created in her hands, caressing them like small totems, using them as a rosary to pray to the saints. But he never came in the door. I tried to sleep, but it was too hard -- Tomas and I had shared a bed forever. How could I sleep without his protective arm around me?

The next morning, we gingerly opened the door and found a basket with a top on it, sitting outside. It was a big basket, like for laundry -- but it wasn't ours. I picked up the lid, and in the basket were body parts: hands, arms, feet, and the like, all neatly cut apart and put in the basket. On one hand I saw the smiling scar from Tomas's run-in with the tin can.

Mama called to me: "Inez, what do you see?"

How could I describe this to her? How could I tell her about the basket and the hand. As it was, I didn't have to. She pushed past me to look for herself.

Mama collapsed onto her knees. "*Dios mio!* My Tomas! My baby! What have you done?" She got sick and tried to throw up. She fell to the ground, sobbing. I put the lid back on the basket and held her as hard as my small body could. She was shaking. There was nothing more I could do, so I just held her and cried with her.

But then I heard another sound: boys playing *futbol.* It seemed so wrong — how could they be playing while we mourned my brother? It was too early in the morning--no neighbors were up getting water, no men were on their way to work. The street was supposed to be quiet, but these boys were *playing a game!* They were having *fun* while *mi hermano*, my dear brother was here, torn apart in that grisly basket. Couldn't he get a little respect? Couldn't we have a few minutes to mourn before confronting the world? I wanted to scream, "STOP PLAYING! THIS IS NO TIME TO HAVE FUN! DON'T YOU UNDERSTAND?! MY BROTHER IS GONE AND THERE IS NO JOY IN THE WORLD. GO HOME!" But the words wouldn't form and no sound came through the terrible lump in my throat.

I looked up--trying to find my voice, trying to show them the pathetic hatred in my eyes--and took a few moments to focus. I recognized some younger gang members. They were laughing and calling to each other. But something was not right, something was out of place. As my brain continued to focus on the boys, my horror grew and grew: they were playing *futbol* with something that wasn't a ball. It was oddly shaped. The colors were wrong. It was the *cabeza,* the head of Tomas! They were kicking around my brother's head!

At that point, I passed out.

That day, my *mama* was determined to have me leave San Pedro Sula as soon as I could. Why? *Por que* the gangs would come after me next. If I were lucky, I would be a messenger or courier. But more likely, I would be one of "their" girls, to be raped whenever they wanted. Or I would be sold to someone who would use me for the same purpose. There are very few jobs for girls. If I refused, I would end up like Tomas. Even if I agreed, I might still end up dead, the sister of Tomas who spit on one of them. What kind of life would that be? No life. If I go home, I will be raped or killed -- it is that simple.

Mama has a cousin living in Houston; his name is Hector Chacon. He can take me in and give me a place to stay. *Mama* wrote to him so he knows am coming. He told me to say the word "asylum" to the Americans if I got here. Please don't make me go back. Please let me stay. If you send me to Honduras, I will surely die. Won't you help me?